



Plant focus: irises

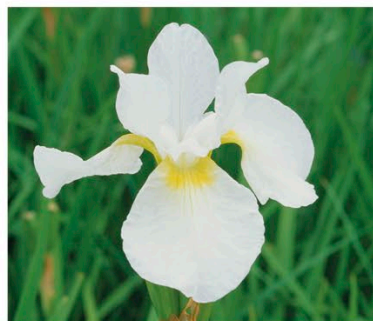
Celebrated for their intricate and widely colored flowers, the iris family includes plants for borders, ponds, and pots.

IRISES COMPRISE A RANGE OF DIFFERENT SPECIES adapted to widely different conditions. They grow from rhizomes or bulbs and, while some thrive in shallow water, others require dry, well-drained soils. Irises that grow from rhizomes are divided into two main groups: bearded and beardless forms. Bearded types are ideal for sunny free-draining borders, with shorter species suitable for rock gardens, alpine beds, or troughs. Prone to rotting, their rhizomes must sit at or above soil level where they are exposed to full sun. Rhizomatic beardless irises have slimmer petals and most prefer well-drained borders in sun or partial shade. However, Louisiana and Laevigatae irises, which thrive in or near ponds, are also part of this group; some are invasive and should be restrained in pond baskets to prevent them from spreading. Bulbous irises include tall Dutch forms suitable for borders and cutting, colorful Juno irises, and tiny Reticulata types, ideal for planting in rock gardens and spring containers.

POPULAR IRIS FORMS



Bearded irises These early summer-flowering irises are characterized by tufted “beards” of soft hairs on the lower petals.



Beardless irises This group has slim hairless petals and includes water irises and Siberian forms that thrive in sun or part shade.



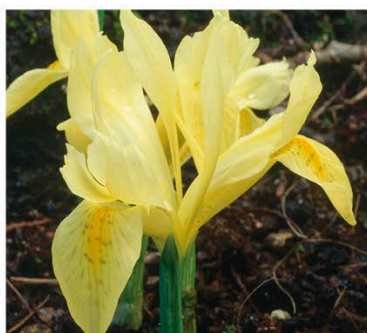
Water irises Beardless *I. laevigata*, *I. versicolor*, *I. ensata*, and the invasive flag iris, *I. pseudacorus*, grow well in shallow water and full sun.



Crested irises With a ridge on their lower petals, these early summer-flowering irises include *I. cristata* and *I. gracilipes*.



Dutch irises Grown from bulbs, these early summer-flowering forms have slim petals and grassy foliage; plant them in sun or part shade.



Reticulata irises These spring-flowering irises bear small, often scented, blooms on short stems, and are dormant from summer to winter.

